

IBISES, BITTERNS, HERONS, AND PELICANS

Most species in the order Pelicaniformes are wetland birds with long legs for walking through marshy or grassy habitats. Their long toes help them to stretch forward when hunting or grasp perches in mangrove swamps or wet thickets. These birds have a long bill for snatching prey.

While most birds in this group eat amphibians and fish, they sometimes eat small mammals and insects as well. Herons, egrets, and bitterns have modified vertebrae, forming an S-shaped neck that gives them lightning-

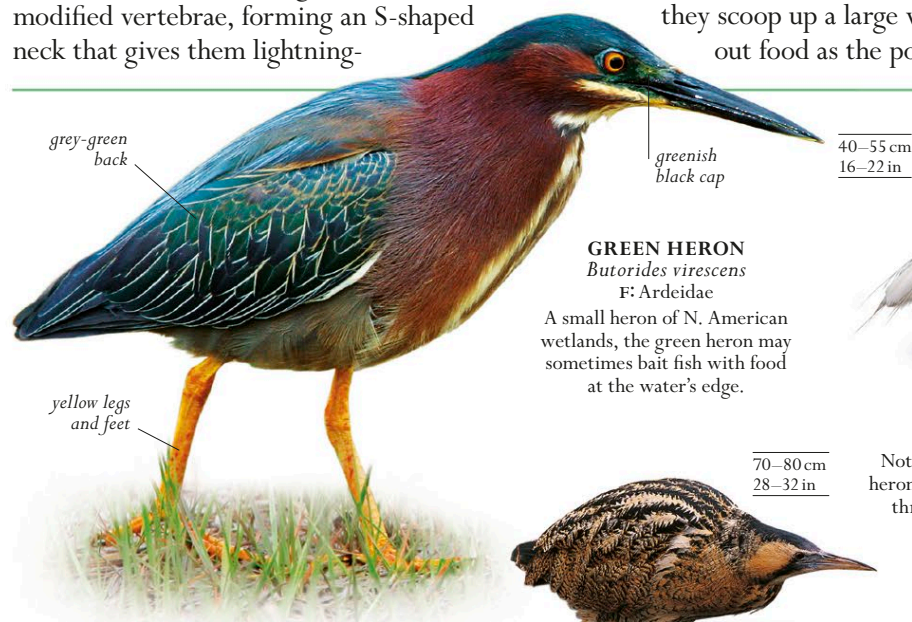
fast thrust to snatch, but not spear, prey. Ibises probe for prey with their thin, curved bill, whereas spoonbills sweep their partly opened bill – with a flat, rounded tip – sideways through shallow water in search of food. The bill snaps shut when prey is detected by touch. Herons and egrets retract their necks in flight, unlike spoonbills and ibises.

Pelicans are massively built, but broad-winged and expert fliers. They have a long bill with a deep, flexible pouch. When feeding (mostly when swimming, but brown pelicans also plunge-dive) they scoop up a large volume of water, filtering out food as the pouch empties.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	AVES
ORDER	PELICANIFORMES
FAMILIES	5
SPECIES	118

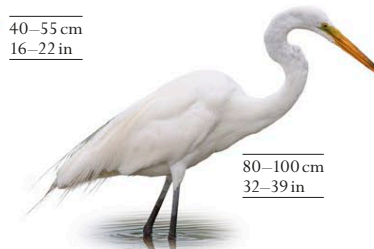


This pelican chick reaches deep into its parent's throat to feed on regurgitated, partly digested fish.



GREEN HERON
Butorides virescens
F: Ardeidae

A small heron of N. American wetlands, the green heron may sometimes bait fish with food at the water's edge.



GREAT EGRET
Ardea alba
F: Ardeidae

Not a true egret but a large white heron, this marsh bird is widespread throughout much of the world.



GREY HERON
Ardea cinerea
F: Ardeidae

Familiar across Eurasia and Africa, the grey heron, like other larger herons, breeds in colonies. It builds stick nests in trees.



LITTLE BITTERN
Ixobrychus minutus
F: Ardeidae

Among the smallest of the heron-bittern family, this skulking Old World species clambers around reeds – sometimes freezing upright in typical bittern manner.



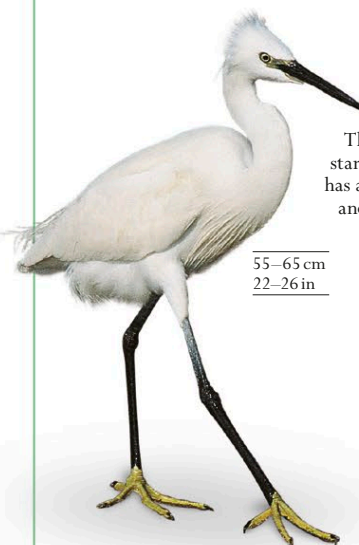
EURASIAN BITTERN
Botaurus stellaris
F: Ardeidae

Like its relatives, this bittern is more frequently heard than seen. It has a loud booming call.



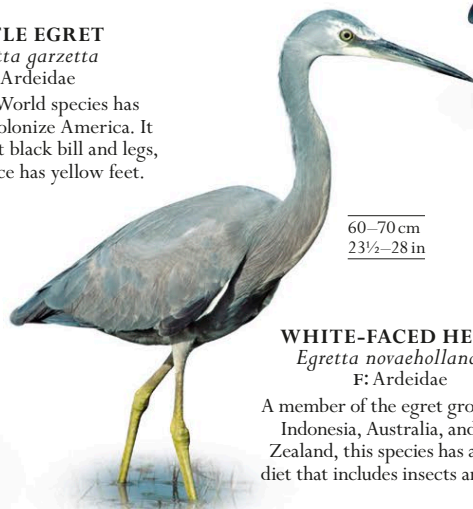
WHITE-NECKED HERON
Ardea pacifica
F: Ardeidae

This large heron of wet regions in Australia and New Guinea hunts for insects and small vertebrates in marshes and grassland.



LITTLE EGRET
Egretta garzetta
F: Ardeidae

This Old World species has started to colonize America. It has a distinct black bill and legs, and one race has yellow feet.



WHITE-FACED HERON
Egretta novaehollandiae
F: Ardeidae

A member of the egret group from Indonesia, Australia, and New Zealand, this species has a varied diet that includes insects and frogs.



TRICOLOURED HERON
Egretta tricolor
F: Ardeidae

This is an inhabitant of American swamps, where, like related species, it uses its dagger-like bill to snatch small animals.



LITTLE BLUE HERON
Egretta caerulea
F: Ardeidae

This American species belongs to the egret group. The purplish head and neck turn grey-blue outside the breeding season.